

"It Helps Me Start": How ADHD Users Adapt AI Tools in Everyday Life

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Abstract

People with ADHD often experience persistent challenges with task initiation and increasingly turn to conversational AI to support everyday activities. We present a qualitative analysis of 147 Reddit posts from r/ADHD and r/ADHD_Programmers (2022–2024) to understand how people with ADHD use AI to support everyday self-support practices. Our findings show that ADHD users appropriate AI as cognitive scaffolding for initiating tasks, actively personalize interactions through prompting, use AI as a low-pressure space for reflection, and critically negotiate trust and reliance boundaries. We discuss implications for designing flexible, user-controlled AI systems that support task initiation while maintaining appropriate safety boundaries for neurodivergent users.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**; *User studies*.

Keywords

ADHD, neurodiversity, generative AI, Reddit

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1 Introduction

Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD) is a prevalent neurodevelopmental condition that affects attention regulation, executive functioning, and emotional control across the lifespan [10, 26, 33]. Adults with ADHD often report challenges with task initiation, planning, and sustained focus in everyday work and learning contexts [10, 26, 33]. As digital tools increasingly mediate cognitive and organizational practices, understanding how interactive systems support or fail to support neurodivergent users has become an important concern within Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) [14, 23, 24].

Recent advances in artificial intelligence (AI), particularly large language models (LLMs), have led to the widespread availability of conversational tools that promise assistance with writing, planning, summarization, and reflection [28]. Prior HCI research has explored AI-based tools designed to support individuals with ADHD and other neurodivergent populations, often focusing on productivity aids, learning supports, or structured task scaffolding [5, 11]. These systems are typically evaluated through controlled studies or designer-led interventions, emphasizing system effectiveness, usability, or accessibility [4, 5, 7]. While this work provides valuable insights, it largely reflects top-down design perspectives and offers a limited understanding of how people with ADHD organically adopt, adapt, and critique AI tools in their everyday lives.

At the same time, social media platforms have emerged as important spaces where individuals with ADHD share lived experiences, coping strategies, and reflections on technology use [9, 31, 37]. Prior research has demonstrated the value of analyzing online communities such as Reddit to study health-related sensemaking, peer support, and technology appropriation in naturalistic settings [25, 36]. However, little is known about how self-identified ADHD users discuss AI tools within these peer-driven environments, particularly in terms of how AI is framed not only as instrumental support, but also as an emotional, reflective, and sometimes risky technology.

In this paper, we present a qualitative analysis of 147 posts and their associated comments from two Reddit communities, r/ADHD and r/ADHD_Programmers, spanning 2022 to 2024. We examine how self-identified ADHD users describe their experiences with AI tools in everyday contexts, including task management, emotional regulation, self-understanding, and boundary-setting. Rather than evaluating specific AI systems, our analysis centers on user-authored narratives and peer discussions, emphasizing lived experience over system performance.

Understanding everyday AI use among people with ADHD is critical for designing support aligned with real needs rather than idealized workflows. By foregrounding user-driven practices, this research informs AI systems that better support task initiation, self-regulation, and user agency while avoiding over-automation or harmful reliance.

This work contributes to HCI research on neurodiversity and AI in three ways. First, it provides empirical evidence of how ADHD users organically repurpose general-purpose conversational AI in everyday life, shifting focus from designer-driven interventions to user-driven appropriation. Second, it challenges conventional assistive technology design by demonstrating that effective AI support



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depends less on built-in features and more on user control and flexibility. Third, it surfaces critical perspectives on AI use, including concerns about trust, boundaries, and system limitations, extending prior HCI research on AI and neurodiversity by foregrounding how neurodivergent users actively negotiate and critique technology in practice.

2 Related Work

2.1 ADHD in Everyday Life: Technology Support and User Agency

Adults with ADHD face persistent challenges with task initiation, planning, and sustained focus in everyday contexts [10, 26, 33]. Prior HCI research has addressed these challenges through structured or assistive technologies, often emphasizing designer-led interventions that embed support through fixed features [22, 27, 29, 30]. In contrast, neurodiversity-informed HCI perspectives foreground lived experience and user agency over deficit-based models, highlighting how neurodivergent users actively adapt and repurpose technologies in practice [3, 11, 23]. This raises an important gap: while prior work has designed bespoke systems for ADHD support, little is known about how ADHD users engage with widely available, general-purpose technologies in their everyday lives.

2.2 AI Tools as General-Purpose Support

Advances in large language models have made conversational AI tools broadly accessible for writing, planning, summarization, and reflection [28]. HCI research has begun examining how people engage with AI in non-expert settings, highlighting themes of trust, reliance, personalization, and critical skepticism [16, 32]. Users actively shape AI interactions through prompting and customization, treating personalization as an ongoing practice rather than a fixed configuration.

Recent work has increasingly examined AI use among neurodivergent populations, including autistic and ADHD individuals in workplace and job-seeking contexts [1, 12, 13, 35], as well as themes of trust, communication assistance, and bias in AI-generated advice for autistic users [20, 34]. However, less is known about how neurodivergent users organically adopt and adapt general-purpose conversational AI in everyday, non-intervention settings. Our work complements this literature by focusing specifically on ADHD and everyday task initiation rather than communication assistance alone.

2.3 Online Communities as Sites of AI Appropriation and Sensemaking

Online communities such as Reddit have emerged as important spaces for health-related sensemaking, peer support, and technology appropriation in naturalistic settings [8, 18]. These communities reveal how individuals share lived experiences, negotiate uncertainty, and collectively interpret technologies through user-driven discourse [19, 21]. ADHD communities on social media platforms, in particular, have become key spaces where individuals exchange coping strategies and reflect on technology use [9, 31, 37]. Our work bridges these areas by examining how self-identified ADHD users discuss, adapt, and critically reflect on conversational

AI within peer-led online communities, extending prior HCI research on technology appropriation and online sensemaking.

3 Method

3.1 Data Source and Dataset

We conducted systematic keyword searches on Reddit within *r/ADHD* (704k subscribers) and *r/ADHD_Programmers* (24.3k subscribers) using keywords including "AI," "ChatGPT," "LLM," and "generative AI." These communities were selected due to their size, sustained activity, and focus on ADHD-related lived experiences. Inclusion criteria were: (1) explicit first-person AI use; (2) self-identified ADHD or ADHD-related experiences; (3) substantive discussion (over 100 words or five or more comments); and (4) English-language posts. Promotional content, passing mentions, and bot-authored posts were excluded.

Data collection yielded 147 threads with 1,243 comments, concluding at thematic saturation. Of these, 87 originated from *r/ADHD* and 60 from *r/ADHD_Programmers*. While the latter may skew toward technically literate users, thematic patterns were consistent across communities, though *r/ADHD_Programmers* posts more frequently referenced code debugging and technical task decomposition. Findings should therefore be interpreted as reflective of active online ADHD communities rather than all adults with ADHD.

3.2 Analysis Approach

We conducted an inductive thematic analysis following established qualitative analysis procedures[2]. Two authors independently performed open coding on an initial subset of the data to identify recurring concepts related to AI use and ADHD experiences, then collaboratively developed a shared codebook. The remaining data were coded using this codebook, with regular team discussions to refine code definitions and ensure consistency. Related codes were grouped into higher-level themes capturing recurring patterns across the dataset. The finalized codebook included definitions and inclusion criteria for each theme and was iteratively refined through team discussion. The codebook may be shared upon reasonable request to support transparency and reproducibility.

3.3 Ethical Considerations

This study analyzed publicly available Reddit posts without direct interaction with users. To mitigate re-identification risks, we removed usernames and identifying information, avoided verbatim quotations, and paraphrased examples to reduce searchability. Consistent with prior HCI research on social media data [19, 36], we treated Reddit posts as public discourse while minimizing potential harm and focusing on aggregate themes rather than individual cases.

In accordance with Reddit's terms of service and ethical considerations regarding sensitive personal disclosures, we do not plan to publicly release the raw dataset. Aggregated coding schemas and analysis materials may be shared upon reasonable request for research purposes.

4 Results

Our analysis of publicly available Reddit posts from self-identified ADHD users revealed four recurring themes describing how individuals experience, adapt, and critically engage with AI tools in everyday contexts. These themes capture how AI is appropriated to support task management, personalization, and emotional reflection, as well as how users negotiate trust, limitations, and boundaries around these systems. We present each theme in turn below.

4.1 AI as Cognitive Scaffolding for Task Initiation and Executive Function

Across the analyzed discussions, AI tools were frequently characterized as cognitive scaffolding to support task initiation and everyday executive functioning. Rather than framing AI as autonomous task completion, users emphasized external support that helped structure thinking, reduce initial overwhelm, and make complex or ambiguous tasks feel more approachable.

Users described turning to AI when struggling to begin work, particularly for activities requiring organization or sustained attention. Common contexts included drafting emails, outlining assignments, planning daily tasks, and breaking larger projects into smaller steps. In these accounts, AI was portrayed as helping externalize scattered thoughts and translate vague intentions into concrete actions, addressing difficulties with task initiation associated with ADHD. For instance, users described prompting AI when feeling stuck on a large assignment or unsure how to begin an email, and receiving stepwise breakdowns (e.g., identifying first small actions or outlining key points) that transformed an ambiguous task into discrete, manageable steps.

Importantly, users framed AI as a supportive scaffold rather than an autonomous agent. AI was described as offering a lightweight structure or prompts that could be adapted or selectively applied, without replacing user agency or decision-making. These lightweight structures included numbered task decompositions, brief bullet-point outlines, or short checklists that users could adapt to their immediate needs. The value of AI lay not in completing tasks independently, but in providing an initial framework that users could modify according to their own judgment and preferences.

4.2 Negotiating Structure and Personalization Through Prompts

A recurring theme across discussions was the active negotiation of how AI systems communicate through prompt customization. Users characterized default AI outputs as overly verbose, unstructured, or overwhelming, leading them to iteratively adapt prompts to better align responses with their cognitive needs. Users actively shaped response length, format, and level of detail through repeated interaction, treating prompting as an ongoing process rather than a one-time configuration.

A common strategy involved explicitly disclosing ADHD when interacting with AI systems. Users described this disclosure as resulting in shorter responses, increased use of bullet points, clearer step-by-step breakdowns, and reduced cognitive load. In these accounts, disclosing ADHD functioned as a pragmatic design strategy

rather than a personal revelation, enabling users to reshape interaction norms and make AI outputs more manageable. Some users maintained persistent instructions or pre-configured prompts emphasizing simplified language and incremental task decomposition, further reinforcing personalization as an ongoing practice.

Users framed this negotiation of structure as essential for making AI tools usable and supportive. Without such customization, AI responses were described as exacerbating overwhelm or disengagement. Through prompt adaptation, users sought to transform what they perceived as neurotypical defaults into interaction styles better aligned with neurodivergent modes of attention, processing, and task engagement. This pattern suggests that effective AI support for ADHD depends less on built-in personalization features and more on users' ability to negotiate interaction structure.

4.3 AI as a Low-Pressure Space for Reflection and Emotional Regulation

Beyond task-oriented support, discussions revealed that users engaged with AI as a low-pressure space for reflection and emotional processing. AI interactions were characterized as non-judgmental and low-stakes, enabling users to articulate thoughts or frustrations without fear of social evaluation. These practices functioned as informal emotional regulation strategies, allowing users to process affective states through structured articulation rather than interpersonal disclosure.

Users described rehearsing difficult conversations with family members or supervisors, or working through feelings of frustration or inadequacy in a private, controlled setting. Users valued AI responses that offered calm, neutral phrasing suggestions, while responses perceived as overly generic or moralizing were described as unhelpful. Some users also turned to AI to avoid feeling like a burden on others, suggesting that AI's perceived low social cost contributed to its appeal as a reflective space.

At the same time, users articulated clear boundaries around AI's role in emotional contexts, framing it as a tool for reflection and self-organization rather than a substitute for professional care or meaningful human relationships.

4.4 Critical Awareness, Mistrust, and Boundary-Setting Around AI Use

Alongside accounts of supportive use, discussions consistently reflected critical awareness and skepticism toward AI tools, particularly in contexts involving mental health, judgment, and personal decision-making. Users frequently raised concerns about misinformation, hallucinated content, and the limitations of AI-generated responses, emphasizing that such systems should not be treated as authoritative sources of truth. These concerns were often articulated collectively within comment threads, suggesting community-level sensemaking around appropriate and inappropriate forms of AI reliance rather than isolated individual caution.

Users described actively establishing boundaries around AI use, stressing that AI should not replace professional expertise, human judgment, or lived experience. In mental health-related discussions, AI was framed as a supplementary resource for reflection, organization, or clarification, often accompanied by explicit warnings against over-reliance or uncritical trust. This boundary-setting was

described as particularly important given users' perceived vulnerability to confident, fluent, or persuasive system outputs, which could obscure underlying inaccuracies or limitations.

In addition, users critiqued outputs that assumed linear productivity workflows or discouraged tangential idea exploration, which some users described as aligned with their associative thinking styles [24, 33]. These critiques highlighted tensions between personalization and concerns about embedded bias and creative constraint. Together, these accounts show that users actively negotiated trust, risk, and responsibility when integrating AI into everyday practices.

5 Discussion

5.1 Adaptive and User-Controlled AI Support for ADHD

Our findings highlight that self-identified ADHD users engage with AI as flexible, user-controlled supports rather than autonomous problem-solvers. AI was appropriated to externalize planning, structure tasks, and reduce cognitive friction during task initiation, functioning as an on-demand resource that users could invoke, adapt, or disengage from as needed.

These findings extend prior work in two ways. While Campbell et al. [5] reported limited awareness of AI tools among ADHD knowledge workers, our analysis captures organic, peer-driven AI adoption outside formal workplace contexts. In addition, whereas recent work has focused on AI for ADHD diagnosis and clinical intervention [4, 7], our findings foreground everyday use of general-purpose AI for task scaffolding, a pattern largely absent from specialized system research.

Personalization emerged as central to effective AI support. Users negotiated interaction styles through prompting, treating personalization as an ongoing, situational practice. This emphasis on user agency contrasts with assistive technologies that embed structure through fixed features [22, 27], aligning instead with neurodiversity-informed HCI perspectives that foreground agency over deficit-based models [11, 23].

5.2 Trust, Risk, and Responsible Boundaries in Mental Health-Adjacent AI Use

Our findings indicate that engagement with AI tools was accompanied by active reflection on trust, risk, and appropriate boundaries, particularly in mental health-adjacent contexts. Users demonstrated awareness of AI limitations, including misinformation and hallucinated content, and engaged in collective sensemaking about when and how AI should be relied upon. While such concerns are well documented in broader AI literature [6, 15], our findings illustrate how they are collectively negotiated within ADHD-specific peer communities, shaping shared norms around appropriate AI reliance rather than reflecting isolated individual caution.

Users consistently articulated boundaries around AI use, emphasizing that such tools should not replace professional expertise, human judgment, or interpersonal support. Rather than rejecting AI outright, users positioned it as a supplementary resource for organization or reflection, actively constructing ethical boundaries

through community discourse rather than relying solely on system-level design [17].

5.3 Implications for Designing AI Systems for Neurodivergent Users

Our findings suggest three concrete design directions for AI systems supporting neurodivergent users. First, AI systems should support *persistent prompt libraries and templates*. Rather than relying on one-time configuration, systems could allow users to save, modify, and reuse personalized instruction sets (e.g., concise responses or step-wise task breakdowns), reflecting observed practices of maintaining recurring prompt strategies to manage cognitive load.

Second, systems could implement *adaptive response previews* that indicate expected response length or structure before full generation. Allowing users to adjust outputs in advance may help mitigate experiences of overwhelm caused by unexpectedly verbose responses.

Third, AI systems in mental health-adjacent contexts should support *transparent limitation disclosure*. Proactively surfacing system boundaries or uncertainty can reinforce responsible use and align with users' boundary-setting practices. Across these implications, our findings emphasize user control and transparency over automation.

6 Limitations and Future Work

This analysis draws on self-identified ADHD users from Reddit and may not represent the full diversity of ADHD populations. We rely on self-reported narratives rather than clinically verified diagnoses and focus on posts explicitly mentioning AI use, potentially excluding implicit practices. While thematic analysis enables rich interpretation of lived experience, it does not support causal claims.

Future research could employ mixed-methods and participatory co-design approaches to examine long-term AI integration, with longitudinal work on transparency, customization, and safeguards informing more responsible and inclusive AI design for neurodivergent users.

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